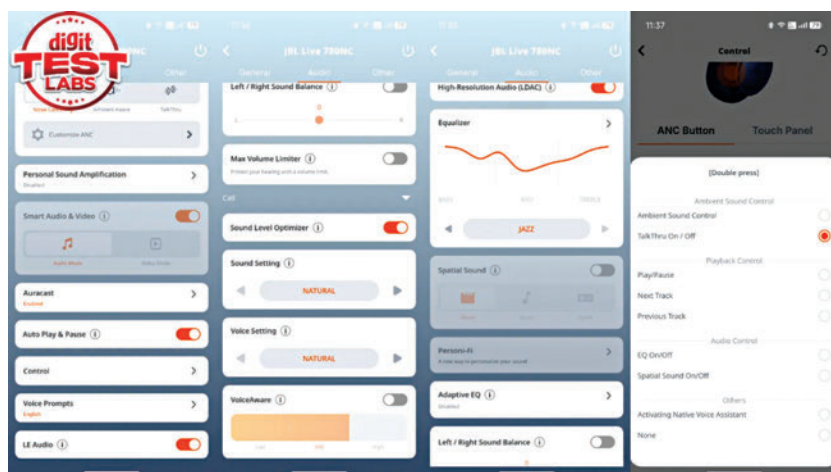


consumers out there as there is an intentional emphasis on bass, while the soundstage is fairly open and key aspects such as vocals and instruments sound rather clear. This was evident in Ain't Nobody from DC (2026), wherein the Live 780NC produces potent bass drops, and the vocals by Anirudh Ravichander and the instruments can be heard clearly.

The default Studio equaliser mode didn't sound much different to my ears. The other modes like Jazz, Vocal and Club can make some difference, but I preferred the default sound still.

While the bass is engaging for the most part, there are moments in certain tracks where you feel it is dominating the mix and slightly masking some of the finer vocal details.

For the best listening experience, I had to listen at full volume. And even at that level, the high strings and vocals in songs like Ghar Aa Maahi (I'm Waiting For You) and Yeh Raat from Bandish Bandits S02 sounded smooth. Harmonic overtones in these tracks sounded clean.

So, the presentation sounds enjoyable and mass-friendly, but the boosted low frequencies lack the natural balance that more neutral headphones offer.

However, the main sticking point for me is that the sound experience here isn't all that different from a lower-priced headphone like the CMF Headphone Pro.

NOISE CANCELLATION

The Live 780NC uses JBL's True Adaptive Noise Cancelling 2.0 with six microphones working to raise the noise cancellation based on the environment you are in. But I chose to keep the cancellation at max level, and the experience was decent. It isn't class-leading or impressive, but it is enough to keep you concentrating on your work or give you some peace from Indian traffic noise.

Transparency mode sounds natural, which is useful for walking on less busy roads and having short conversations without removing the headphones.

During meetings and normal phone conversations, people on the other end reported hearing me clearly, while background noise remained well controlled.

VERDICT

After spending several days using the Live 780NC across work, entertainment and travel, I have realised it is made to give a well-rounded and feature-rich ownership experience. It is cool, comfortable, and well-built. The folding design makes it very portable. And the control options are plenty and easily accessible. It has one of the best companion apps in the segment with standout features like Bluetooth 6.0, Auracast, a 10-band equaliser and a lot more. The audio tuning is bass-leaning and good for most everyday music, movies and other media you consume.

And the battery lasts long enough for you to forget about charging it.

More importantly, nothing about the headphones became frustrating enough for me to wrap up with the review quickly and move on.

However, I still hold reservations about recommending it to all. If you are someone wanting a neutral sound, this ain't it. Even the built-in equaliser can't do much about that. The lack of passive wired playback is a clear and weird limitation. And as you have read above, the touch controls don't always reliably respond.

These aren't major shortcomings that should deter you from considering them. But they are things you should know while deciding. And if your priorities include long battery life, extensive software customisation, reliable everyday ANC and a bass-forward sound, then the Live 780NC should be on your shortlist.

– G S Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Driver size: 40 mm | Microphones: 4 | Impedance: 32 Ohms | Dynamic Frequency response range: 10 - 40k Hz | Charging: 2 hours to full | Play time (ANC): 50 hrs | Play time (without ANC): 80 hrs | App: JBL Headphones

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